CHAPTER 6 The Tool: Jeopardy The Higher Force: Willpower

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Internal

Most self-help books don't even deal with the issue of quitting. They may give you a program, but they're unrealistic about how hard it will be to stick to it. We don't want to soft-pedal the challenge of changing your life—and we don't have to. That's because we can make you strong enough to pass the test.

How can this be so widespread? The answer is that our entire culture has an unreal view of what it means to be human. We like to think of ourselves as finished products—complete on our own. We're not. To be whole, we need to stay connected to something beyond ourselves. The constant effort that requires means that a human being can never be more than a work in progress. Think of your mind as a newly bought, state-of-the-art, flat-screen TV. You eagerly take it out of the box, but it won't play. An electrical connection has come loose; there's no buying a new connection, you have to fix it with your own effort. Worse, the connection will keep coming loose—you'll have to fix it every day. But the broken connection in your mind isn't to electrical power, it's to higher forces. And every time the connection breaks, one of your personal problems appears. The tools repair the connection—that's why they work. But the connection never lasts; it will break again. That makes using tools a task without end. Now you know why almost every patient quit using the tools. It wasn't enough that their lives were improving in every way. They wanted what the tools could never bring them—a magic pill to exonerate them from the struggle. Spiritually, they were still children.

Our entire culture is demoralized. All the symptoms are there: we delight in the adrenal rush of cheap sex and petty violence; we avoid real problem solving in favor of scoring points against our opponents. We've lost hope in our future. That's the ultimate price for indulging childish fantasies. Exoneration is impossible—for an individual or for a society. When, inevitably, this false hope for "easy street" is shattered, we're left demoralized. This is an inescapable law: *exoneration always ends in demoralization.* There's a path that can lead us out of this mess. But we have an enemy that's dead set against us taking it. It attacks us every waking moment: when we turn on the TV, go on the Internet, or read a magazine; it gets to us even while we're driving, and especially when we enter the dark, inner sanctum of its power, the shopping mall.

FANTASY FOR SALE

The enemy is called "consumerism." It speaks to us through every advertisement, endorsement, logo, roadside billboard, etc. Its underlying message is always the same: there's something out there you must have. Helpless to resist, we feel compelled to acquire thing after thing. Yet we don't enjoy each new item for long; once we possess it, we shift our focus to the next thing. Inevitably, consumerism insinuates itself into all of our activities, not just shopping. We consume life experiences the same way we consume iPods, jeans, and European cars. A given song, idea, or friend is new and different until it's not. Then we discard it and go on to the next thing. Consumerism has become our model for living. This is the tail wagging the dog.

Change only happens through the faithful use of the tools. You might read something that inspires you to use them, but your resolve will fade quickly and you'll quit. It's like the old joke "When I feel the urge to work, I lie down 'til it passes." Only it's not funny. Consumers try to make up for their laziness by gorging on new information—TV, podcasts, web searches, texts, e-mails, etc. But like a meal eaten too quickly, nothing is really digested. Trying to consume spirituality is like buying multiple GPS systems for your car and not learning to use any of them. As obvious as the presence of consumerism is in our lives, we still can't resist it. Its power is actually based on something healthy. We have a natural desire for a relationship with higher forces that's so strong it can never be eradicated. Consumerism misdirects that desire by convincing you that higher forces exist *inside* the magical something. That way, once you obtain it, you *own* the higher forces; you don't need a relationship with them. This "treasure hunt" is a quest for the impossible, but rather than admitting that, we relentlessly search for the next magical something.

THE HIGHER FORCE: WILLPOWER

It's a rare individual who feels she couldn't use more of it—usually much more. We call on willpower when we have to do something difficult or unpleasant: working out, balancing a checkbook, even getting up in the morning. Or we call on it when we need to restrain harmful impulses such as overeating or drug use. These are situations where the world around you is of no help—in fact, you have to act despite it. You need a force you can generate completely from inside yourself. Western culture represents it as a light appearing in the darkness, as if out of nowhere. That was the spark Vinny saw.

Very few models of human growth accept this, let alone give you a way to build your willpower. Instead, they pretend it's easy to change your life. It isn't. Our approach is the opposite: we're telling you the truth about how difficult it's going to be—and we're going to make you strong enough to face the challenge. Doing that means increasing your willpower—which is what the fifth tool does. In a sense it's the most important one—the tool that makes sure you keep using the other tools. It won't matter how effective the other four are if you don't use them.

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Those four are given to us as gifts. Willpower isn't. Human beings participate in its creation. The universe is involved, but only to provide the context in which human beings develop willpower. Our darkness comes at those moments when we're completely demoralized and want to give up. We rarely understand what a gift the darkness is. Without it, there would be no way to discover our own inner spark. It's exactly when we're demoralized that the universe becomes our partner. Demoralization is actually our most sacred moment.

But only if we know what to do with it. That's why we need a fifth tool.

THE TOOL: JEOPARDY

In effect, we need a tool that generates the spark of willpower that got the boxer off the canvas and that you will need to get through your darkest moments of demoralization. That spark is more than the resolution to do something in the future (just look back at your last New Year's resolutions). The tool must move you to act right now. The choice is black or white: you either use the tools or you don't. To act right now requires a sense of urgency. But urgency is uncomfortable. The only time we feel it is when we're in jeopardy of losing something important: a job, a relationship, physical safety. An upcoming recital might put a musician's reputation in jeopardy, so she practices twice as much. A business presentation might put an executive's promotion at stake, so he stays up all night preparing. From here on—for the sake of brevity—we'll call this kind of situation simply "jeopardy." It triggers a burst of energy you can't get any other way.

For most of us, the truth—that every moment counts—is too much pressure to bear. It would mean giving our all, all of the time. We prefer to stay comfortable until a deadline forces us to act. But deadlines pass and the willpower they trigger goes away.

“Real willpower can’t be dependent on events, willpower has to be beyond events.”

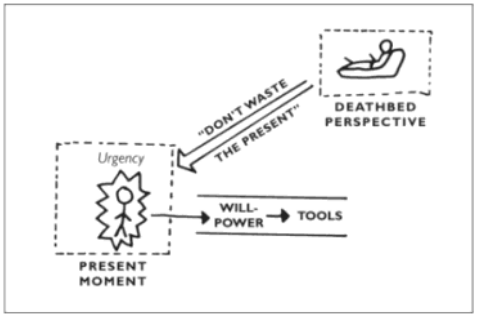
Most people don’t think of the future as something that’s theirs to lose. But that changes if you use the tools regularly. Not only does this enable you to overcome your problems in the present, it changes who you become in the future. Whether you’re a novelist, an entrepreneur, or a parent, you become capable in a way you never were before. You become a party to the shaping of your own future. With access to higher forces, your potential has no limits. If you keep using the tools, this limitless potential is your future. But the benefit is not automatic. All you have to do is stop using them and your potential is destroyed. That raises the stakes. Your future is in jeopardy every moment. That generates tremendous urgency—and the willpower that comes with it. The penalty for not using the tools is much greater than we’d like to admit.

Each person has his own version of a destroyed future. Whatever it is for you, the pain and regret it causes is enormous. To keep yourself from quitting on the tools, you’ll need a way to stay aware of how much is at stake. That’s what the fifth tool does. It’s this awareness that creates the urgency that triggers unwavering willpower. Because the tool is based on the risk of losing your future, we call it “Jeopardy.” When we use the word with a capital *J* it refers to the tool. In some ways, it’s the most important one—it’s your insurance policy against quitting on the other four tools.

Jeopardy

Jeopardy

Imagine you can see far into the future. See yourself lying on your deathbed. This older self knows how crucial the present moment is, because he’s run out of them. You see him rouse himself from his bed and scream at you not to waste the present moment. You feel a deep, hidden fear that you’ve been squandering your life. This creates an urgent pressure to use—right now—the basic tool you selected above.



WHEN TO USE JEOPARDY

Although Jeopardy is effective at any time, there are certain moments when it’s most crucial. Identifying these moments will help you recognize the cues to use the tool.

We all have moments when we want to use the tools but just can’t. We may not be as demoralized as he was; maybe we chalk it up to laziness or exhaustion. It doesn’t matter. Once you find it impossible to use the tools, the only thing that can help you is extra willpower. That’s the cue to use Jeopardy. We mistake success with being exonerated from further struggle. We tell ourselves we no longer need to exert willpower. But no matter how good we feel, if it becomes an excuse to quit using the tools, success destroys our future. That defines the second cue. Any time we feel like we’ve grown beyond the need for the tools is an immediate cue to use Jeopardy.

Obviously, our tendency to quit isn’t limited to the tools. We quit diets, exercise programs, writing self-help books, relationships, etc. In all of these situations what’s needed is increased willpower. Jeopardy works just as well here as it does for getting yourself to use the tools. So consider this a third cue. Whenever you lose the will to go on in life areas that are important to you, Jeopardy is your friend.

Willpower is the missing link in reaching human potential. Because it’s so crucial, you’ll discover many other situations where you need it. Try out Jeopardy in those everyday moments when you tend to lose your will: getting out of bed in the morning, concentrating in the face of distractions, or restraining the impulse to give in to a bad habit. It works just as well at those heightened moments when you’d like to take your life in a new direction. You might want to start a book, a new business, or move to a new city. You fantasize about it endlessly but you don’t even take step one. We’ll elaborate on these other uses of Jeopardy at the end of this chapter.

Jeopardy is more than a tool. It’s a model for being fully alive. Paradoxically, this sense of life emerges from a relationship with the deathbed version of yourself. Because he knows what it’s like for time to run out, he has the wisdom you need every moment. Invite him into your consciousness, feel him looking at you every moment, and welcome the pressure he puts on you. You’ll move through life with a wind at your back.

THE SECRET BENEFIT OF WILLPOWER

The consumer expects a reward for the slightest effort—or better, for no effort at all. He cares only about what he gets from the world, not about what he might add to it. Living on the surface, jumping from thing to thing, his energy is diffused, like milk spreading across a tabletop. He makes no impact on the world; when his time on earth is over, it’s as if he never lived.

The creator won’t accept that fate. Everything he does is with the intention of making an impact on the world. His code ensures this:

He doesn’t accept the world as he finds it; he brings things into the world that aren’t already there.

He doesn’t follow the herd; he sets his own course. He ignores the reactions of others.

He resists superficial distractions. He remains focused on his goals even if he has to sacrifice his immediate gratification.

Anyone can live by this code, but very few of us do. It means putting your life in the service of higher forces. These forces can’t be found on the surface of life; they’re found in its depths. The creator’s energy must have the singular focus of a drill boring through stone. As difficult as that is, a creator is rewarded many times over for his efforts. You don’t have to be an artist to be a creator. You can add something to the world in any human activity—even the most routine. Your

job, your role as a parent, your relationships, your contribution to your community—all become more meaningful when you put your personal stamp on them using higher forces.

An old rabbi was teaching his student about God's creation of the human race. God labored carefully to create man in His own image. When He was finished, He looked at His creation but was unsatisfied; He'd wanted to create a being he could relate to, a peer. But man was lacking one key attribute that God had—the ability to create. So God made the earth and placed man in its challenging environment. Man was forced to create—build shelter, raise crops, invent the wheel. Now man had all the attributes of God. The student was confused. "Why did God go to all this trouble? Why not just give man creative powers?" The old rabbi replied, "That is the one thing that cannot be given."

Creative power can't be given because the act of creation is an expression of yourself, a revelation of who you are inside. No one, not even God, can give this to you—*it must come from you*. You have to develop creative powers through your own efforts.

When consumers say, "taking care of us," they really mean exonerating us from the struggle. But the story explains that God's real "job" is to keep us *in the struggle*. This view of God doesn't go down well when your ultimate goal is a life of ease. I've found that even atheists reject it. (Just in case there is a God, they want to make sure He serves their false hopes.) It's the chance to live as a creator, the deepest, most meaningful experience we can have. If God did exonerate us, He'd be taking that opportunity away from us. Human beings are only happy when they are reaching toward their highest potential. Paracelsus, a Renaissance physician and mystic, put it this way: "Happiness does not consist in laziness.… In labour and in sweat must each man use the gifts that God conferred upon him on earth, …"

In modern terms, the rabbi's story was about God's need for man to become a creator. Only then, would God have a peer. That's why "they make it so hard." Our existence has to be difficult, or we never find our way to the potential God wants us to have. The most immediate experience we can have of being a creator is when we use Jeopardy. The tool allows us to literally create willpower out of nothing. The spiritual model for creating something out of nothing is described in Genesis, where darkness reigned until God said, "Let there be light." In our lives, darkness reigns when we're demoralized and can't act. When we use Jeopardy to create the spark of willpower, we bring light into our personal universe the same way that God brought it to the cosmos. This completely transforms the meaning of failure, demoralization, and paralysis. They all become opportunities for us to exercise a godlike creativity. If you can do this, you've marked yourself as a creator—independent of outer achievements. You become fearless. The future may bring you darkness, but it can't take away your ability to create light.

Jeopardy supplies you with the willpower to control addictive and impulsive behavior. *We have much less control over ourselves than we'd like to think. Whether it's what we eat, what we buy, or how we react to other people, etc., we can't resist the pull of immediate gratification. We resolve repeatedly to change our behavior, but impulses always win in the end. What we need isn't more resolutions; it's a way to defeat our impulses right in the moment. That takes willpower.*

Jeopardy gives you the strength to concentrate in circumstances where you usually space out or get distracted. *We've become a society of hyperactive multitaskers, with the attention span of a flea. We need a force strong enough to hold our concentration on one thing until we're finished with it. That takes willpower.*

Jeopardy enables you to start new ventures. *One of the hardest things to do in life is to start something new: moving to a new city, developing a relationship with someone thrust into your life (stepchildren, in-laws, etc.), starting a new business. Each of these steps—and any other new undertaking—triggers the most primal of human fears: fear of the unknown. We gravitate toward the familiar, even if it's not good for us, because we lack the will to push through that fear. Jeopardy creates a force of will stronger than our fear.*

SUMMARY OF JEOPARDY

What the Tool Is For

By now, you should know how to use each of the basic tools described in Chapters 2 through 5. But no matter how effective they've been, you'll find yourself quitting them. Not only will quitting stop your progress, it will destroy all the gains you've made up until this point. This is the fundamental obstacle every reader faces.

What You're Fighting Against

The illusion that you can obtain a "magical something" that will exonerate you from using the tools. This is reinforced day and night by the consumer culture that surrounds you. The illusion always leads to the same result: you quit. In success, you think the tools are no longer necessary; and in failure, you're too demoralized to use them.

Cues to Use the Tool

1. In any situation where you know you need a tool but, for whatever reason, can't get yourself to use one.
2. When you feel you've grown beyond the need for the tools.

The Tool in Brief

See yourself lying on your deathbed. Having run out of time, this older self screams at you not to waste the present moment. You feel a deep, hidden fear that you've been squandering your life. This creates an urgent desire to use whichever basic tool you need at that moment.

The Higher Force You're Using

You can't overcome the tendency to quit by thinking about it. You need a higher force. We call that force willpower. It's the one higher force you must create yourself; all the universe can do is provide a challenge that demands you generate it.